India's relationships—and thus any potential dependence—and maximize the country's aid options.[59] But, although there was a debate in Moscow about India policy, Soviet leader Joseph Stalin saw India as an Anglo-American stooge, which Nehru resented. There were other irritants as well. The Indian prime minister believed Moscow was guiding the Indian communist party's increasingly hostile approach.[60] Nehru was also critical of "Russia's active expansionism" and "apparent lack of any sense of ethics in international affairs."[61] In addition, Soviet offers and terms of assistance had fallen short.[62] It was also harder to deal with differences since Indian policymakers had few avenues to communicate with officials from the Soviet Union or its satellites.[63] It was in this context that Delhi looked to Washington, and Nehru traveled to the US in October 1949.

Colliding Positions (1949–1952)

The Indian prime minister's visit would reveal crucial differences between India and the US on communism, the Soviet Union, and China. These disagreements would only intensify, with crucial implications for US-India relations over the rest of Truman's term and even beyond it.

Red China or New China? Comparing Notes (1949–1950)

China was a key subject of discussion between American and Indian policymakers during Nehru's visit. He outlined both his perception of and his preferred policy toward China. He felt Guomindang mismanagement had created the space for the communists. Communism, he believed, was "alien to the Chinese mind." "Foreign domination" would be disliked, and nationalism, growing everywhere in Asia, would eventually return as the "governing force" in China—and, meanwhile, serve to limit Sino-Soviet cooperation. Nehru gave Acheson the impression that India was "leaning toward early recognition," explaining that "India's proximity to China" made it view this issue differently.[64] Acheson did not believe that early recognition would give India any advantage. Moreover, it was not clear that the communists controlled all of China or that they had the backing of the Chinese people—both necessary elements before the US would even consider recognition. Furthermore, he worried about the impact of recognition on those still resisting the communists. Finally, he felt the